

BEST IN THEATER

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Chicago Tribune



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SUNDAY, DECEMBER 15, 2024

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Wheeling, dealing fall short for budget

For Johnson's team, lost political capital has hobbled horse-trading

By Alice Yin and A.D. Quig

Chicago Tribune

Before Mayor Brandon Johnson's latest bid to secure passage of his 2025 budget plan fell apart last week, his team raced to make up for the past year and a half's damage to his relationships with aldermen in just a few days.

The progressive mayor and self-dubbed "collaborator-in-chief" resorted (with mixed results) to the kind of old-school horse-trading for budget support that was a hallmark of Democratic machine predecessors, but fell short of a council majority and canceled the up-or-down budget vote Friday morning rather than suffer a historically embarrassing defeat.

Now, with an end-of-year deadline bearing down on him to pass the \$17.3 billion spending plan, and holdout aldermen further empowered to demand even greater concessions or sweeteners in exchange for their backing, Johnson has to figure out what to do to persuade a handful more of them to change their minds.

Tick tock. The latest bevy of backroom negotiations this week did boast a few successful examples of wheeling and dealing reminiscent of Mayors Richard M. Daley and Rahm Emanuel, but apparently not enough to guarantee a Friday victory. So Johnson told the council to come back to try again Monday afternoon.

The freshman mayor who promised bold progressive investments and no property tax increases — only to propose a 2025 budget that satisfies neither — has until Dec. 31 to win a majority of Chicago's 50 aldermen or risk a historic government shutdown. What happens next is anyone's guess, but City Hall observers say they already expect the recent chaos that's dominated Johnson's second budget process to usher in long-lasting ramifications for Chicago's political ecosystem.

Even aldermen planning to vote for the mayor's budget say this

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CULTURE OF CORRUPTION



PAPER TIGERS

Intentionally weak government oversight gives Illinois public officials cover for misconduct

By Dan Petrella and Gregory Royal Pratt | Chicago Tribune

Carol Pope lasted only about two years as the Illinois General Assembly's inspector general before quitting in frustration.

When Pope, whose job was to investigate allegations of wrongdoing by legislators and their staffers, asked for more autonomy amid a burgeoning corruption scandal in the legislature, lawmakers instead passed a law limiting her powers.

The legislative inspector general "has no real power to effect change or shine a light on ethics violations," Pope, a former state prosecutor and judge, wrote in a scathing resignation letter in 2021. "The position is essentially a paper tiger."

In Chicago, aldermen shut down the inspector general's office charged with overseeing the City Council nearly a decade ago after the first occupant, attorney Faisal Khan, repeatedly butted heads with council members as Khan looked into complaints of misconduct.

Above: Carol Pope, a retired prosecutor and judge, resigned as inspector general for the Illinois General Assembly after lawmakers rejected her calls for more autonomy and instead placed new restrictions on her office. **E.JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

NEXT SUNDAY: How Illinois and Chicago can reduce corruption.

ONLINE: Find the ongoing Culture of Corruption series at chicagotribune.com/corruption.

Like Pope, Khan viewed the elected officials' actions as thinly veiled attempts to protect themselves from scrutiny.

"This office wouldn't be closing if they wanted oversight," he said at the time.

The frustrations Pope and Khan experienced in being the internal watchdogs for two notoriously crooked government bodies underscore a key factor in Illinois' pervasive political corruption: Public officials create systems of oversight that often thwart meaningful accountability for elected officials and government employees.

A Tribune review of Illinois and Chicago ethics laws found consistent weaknesses in the systems, including:

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MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL

Prosecutors set to rest; tapes could help tell tale



Former Illinois House Speaker Michael Madigan, right, arrives at the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse in Chicago for the start of his trial on Oct. 21. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Jurors will decide if words are corrupt actions or just politics

By Jason Meisner and Megan Crepeau

Chicago Tribune

Unless Michael Madigan shocks the Illinois political world and testifies at his own federal corruption trial, the only thing the jury will have heard from him when it soon comes time to decide his fate is what's on federal tape.

Over the past eight weeks, prosecutors have brought forth an onslaught of evidence in a case that sprawls over nearly a decade and involves big-ticket legislation, large utilities, nitty-gritty ward politics and glitzy real estate developments from the West Loop to Chinatown.

Jurors have seen the powerful

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INSIDE



JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

As Bears tumble, all eyes on Poles

General manager Ryan Poles is in line to hire another Bears coach, but within league circles, some wonder if he should get that chance. **Chicago Sports**

Polio vaccine seen as global lifesaver

Health experts pan push from ally of Robert F. Kennedy Jr. to revoke FDA approval. **Nation & World**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 43 Low 39

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 20

\$5.75 city and suburbs and elsewhere 177th year No. 350 © Chicago Tribune

